

a small pond or water feature. Marginal plants thrive in shallow water. Many are planted just below the surface, while water irises prefer a depth of about 6in (15cm), and pickerel weeds (*Pontederia*) like their roots submerged to a depth of 12in (30cm).

Marginals help disguise liners at the edges of ponds, create reflections, and provide wildlife cover. They have a range of habits, from the bog bean (*Menyanthes trifoliata*) with its clusters of white flowers in spring, to the flowering rush (*Butomus umbellatus*) with its umbels of small pink flowers, and the large, arum-like blooms of skunk cabbages (*Lysichiton*). Larger areas can be enhanced by bold clumps of cattails (*Typha latifolia*), while architectural plants, such as *Pontederia cordata*, provide focal points with their leaves and flower spikes.

The damp areas around the edges of a pond provide ideal conditions for bog natives and moisture-lovers. In very wet bogs, marginals will survive, but in drier conditions, opt for moisture-lovers. Bog gardens must have either drainage or water flowing through them to provide oxygen for the plant roots.

Designing with water plants

Every garden has space for a water feature and its associated plants, but try to match your plants to the size and design of your pond. Informal ponds are designed with sloping sides and boggy banks to attract amphibians, birds, and small mammals that prey on garden pests. In winter, water that is more than 24in (60cm) deep will help creatures to survive a long freeze. The great



advantage of an informal pond is that it offers versatility: its sinuous margins are longer than straight-sided ponds of a similar size, and the sloping banks provide a range of planting depths, increasing your choice of plants.

In small gardens, avoid vigorously spreading plants, such as the flag iris (*Iris pseudacorus*) or *Glyceria maxima*. For architectural plants for bogs, try *Filipendula camtschatica* and *Miscanthus sacchariflorus*. Astilbes, trollius, primulas, and ferns provide color around the edges.

Seasonal care

In fall, cut away dead foliage, trim overgrown plants, and remove weeds. It is also a good idea to place a net over ponds close to deciduous trees, as the fallen leaves can

ABOVE Marginal planting

The curving edges of an informal pond offer ideal conditions for marginals such as *Pontederia cordata* and *Sagittaria latifolia*. Marginals disguise plastic liners and provide shelter for wildlife.

foul the water. Aim to reach a balance, so that rotting vegetation releases enough nutrition for next year's growth, but not so much as to encourage algae.

Water plants are best divided and repotted in spring as they start into growth. Keep planting baskets weeded, removing annual weed seedlings as they appear, as well as surplus water-plant seedlings. This task can be eased by deadheading the plants after flowering. Small ponds and water features will also need topping off in summer, using rainwater if possible.

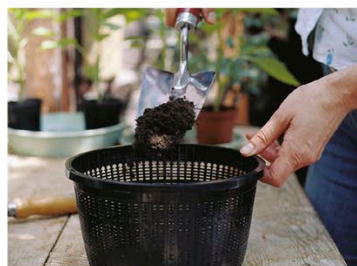
PLANTING UP A POND

Submerged plants are planted in baskets rather than pots, using aquatic potting mix. Garden soil is unsuitable because it often contains nutrients that encourage the growth of algae. When choosing plants, look for healthy

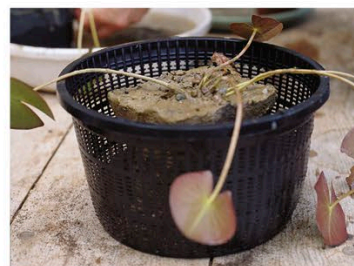
specimens that are free of algae and pond weeds. All submerged plants, such as water lilies and oxygenators, can be planted in the same way. Lift them from the pond for dividing and repotting every 2 or 3 years.



Established water lily pond



1 Use a pond basket
Choose a pond basket with small holes to prevent soil from leaking out into the water. Place a layer of aquatic potting mix in the bottom.



2 Position the plant
Remove the plant from its pot and put it in the center of the basket at the same level. Fill around the plant with more potting mix, firming as you go.



3 Mulch with gravel
Clean any algae or duckweed from the plant's leaves and stems. Wash some pea gravel and apply a thin layer to stabilize the soil's surface.